

## Primary Source Reading 2: Bentham's *Principles of Morals and Legislation*, Chapter IV — Value of a Lot of Pleasure or Pain, How to Be Measured

*Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 2.03 — The Greatest Happiness Principle By Jeremy Bentham (1789/1823)*

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**Before you read:** This is Bentham's attempt to turn moral judgment into an actual calculation — the “hedonic calculus” the lesson asks you to evaluate. As you read, count the dimensions carefully and notice which ones seem straightforwardly measurable and which ones seem to require judgment calls that a “calculus” shouldn't need.

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### Pleasures and Pains as the Legislator's Instruments

Pleasures then, and the avoidance of pains, are the ends that the legislator has in view; it behoves him therefore to understand their value. Pleasures and pains are the instruments he has to work with: it behoves him therefore to understand their force, which is again, in other words, their value.

### Four Circumstances for a Single Person

To a person considered by himself, the value of a pleasure or pain considered by itself, will be greater or less, according to the four following circumstances:

1. Its intensity.
2. Its duration.
3. Its certainty or uncertainty.
4. Its propinquity or remoteness.

### Two More, When Considering an Act

These are the circumstances which are to be considered in estimating a pleasure or a pain considered each of them by itself. But when the value of any pleasure or pain is considered for the purpose of estimating the tendency of any act by which it is produced, there are two other circumstances to be taken into the account; these are,

5. Its fecundity, or the chance it has of being followed by sensations of the same kind: that is, pleasures, if it be a pleasure: pains, if it be a pain.
6. Its purity, or the chance it has of not being followed by sensations of the opposite kind: that is, pains, if it be a pleasure: pleasures, if it be a pain.

These two last, however, are in strictness scarcely to be deemed properties of the pleasure or the pain itself; they are not, therefore, in strictness to be taken into the account of the value of that pleasure or that pain. They are in strictness to be deemed

properties only of the act, or other event, by which such pleasure or pain has been produced.

### A Seventh Dimension, When Considering a Number of Persons

To a number of persons, with reference to each of whom to the value of a pleasure or a pain is considered, it will be greater or less, according to seven circumstances: to wit, the six preceding ones; viz.

1. Its intensity.
2. Its duration.
3. Its certainty or uncertainty.
4. Its propinquity or remoteness.
5. Its fecundity.
6. Its purity.

And one other; to wit:

7. Its extent; that is, the number of persons to whom it extends; or (in other words) who are affected by it.

### How to Sum Up the Tendency of an Act

To take an exact account then of the general tendency of any act, by which the interests of a community are affected, proceed as follows. Begin with any one person of those whose interests seem most immediately to be affected by it: and take an account,

1. Of the value of each distinguishable pleasure which appears to be produced by it in the first instance.
2. Of the value of each pain which appears to be produced by it in the first instance.
3. Of the value of each pleasure which appears to be produced by it after the first. This constitutes the fecundity of the first pleasure and the impurity of the first pain.

### The Memorial Verses

Not long after the publication of the first edition, the following memoriter verses were framed, in the view of lodging more effectually, in the memory, these points, on which the whole fabric of morals and legislation may be seen to rest.

*Intense, long, certain, speedy, fruitful, pure*— Such marks in pleasures and in pains endure. Such pleasures seek if private be thy end: If it be public, wide let them extend. Such pains avoid, whichever be thy view: If pains must come, let them extend to few.

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**After you read:** Notice that Bentham presents this as a genuine procedure — something a legislator could actually sit down and perform, dimension by dimension, for every person affected by a proposed law. As you prepare your discussion post, think about which of the seven dimensions could plausibly be measured with any precision (duration and certainty seem closer to measurable) and which ones seem to smuggle in judgments that the calculus was supposed to avoid (how would you measure “purity” or “fecundity” for a pleasure you have

never experienced before?). Also notice something the lesson will press on directly: this whole chapter assumes that pleasure and pain are the right things to be measuring in the first place. Whether that assumption survives Nozick's experience machine is a separate question from whether Bentham's seven dimensions are the right way to measure it.